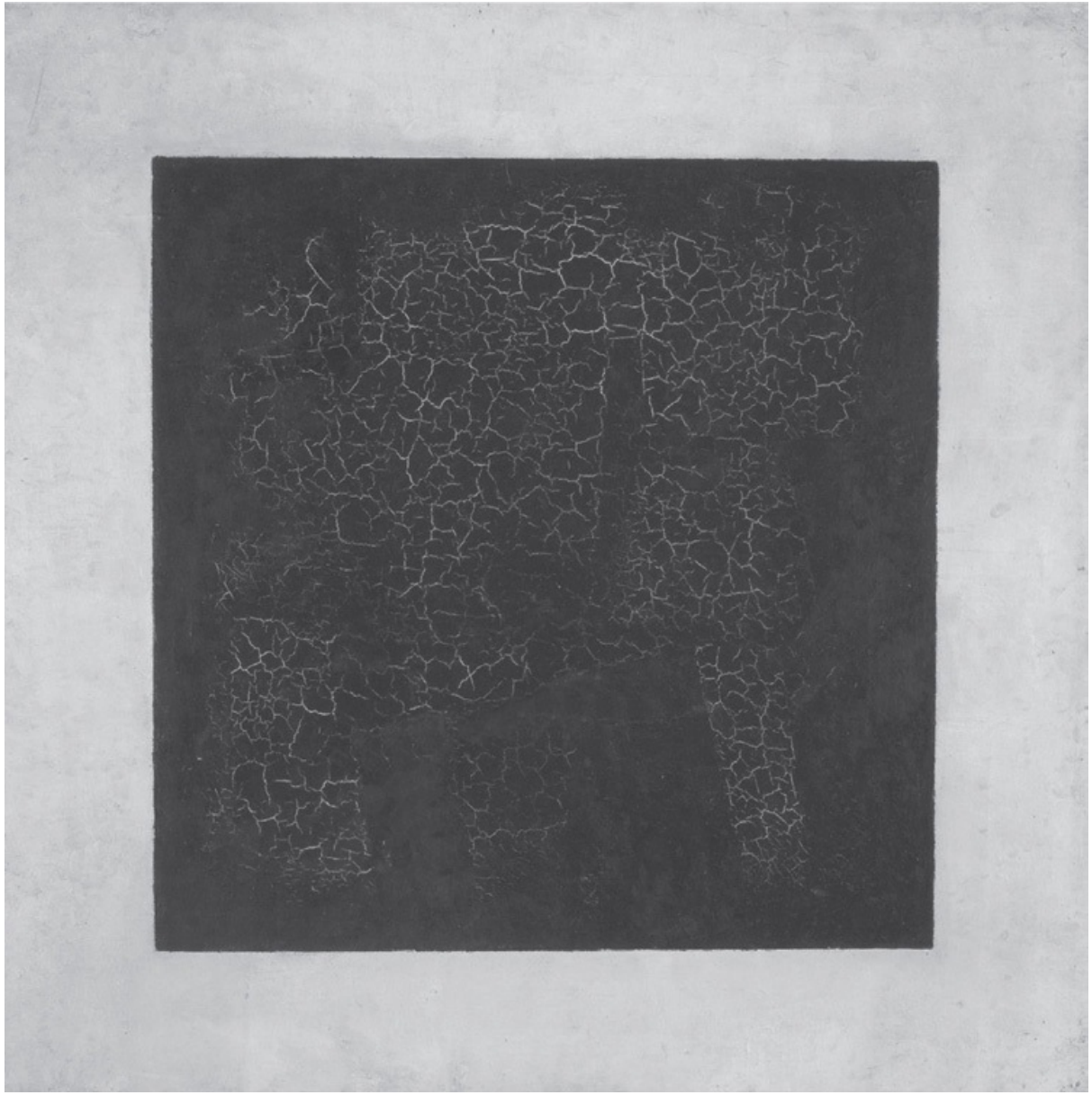


Suprematism

In 1915 in Russia, Kazimir Malevich (1878–1935) produced his first painting of a large black square on a white background, marking the beginning of the movement known as Suprematism. He perceived his works – rectangles, lines and circles in limited colours, emphasizing the shape and flat surfaces of his canvases – as the ultimate balance of positive and negative, superior to all past art. Inspired partly by Cubism and Futurism, and also by his spiritual beliefs, he believed pure abstraction had great power and would give viewers ‘the supremacy of pure feeling’. The purity of the colours and forms were intended to encourage viewers to contemplate deeper ideas than superficial appearances.

The first Suprematist exhibition, held in St Petersburg in 1915, included 35 of Malevich’s paintings. In 1927, he published *The Non-Objective World*, a book that became extremely important in the development of abstract art. Malevich felt Suprematism was well suited to post-revolutionary Russia, but despite early support, the Communist authorities later attacked the movement.



Malevich, *Black Square*, 1915